

Pender County Economic Profile

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Executive Summary

Performance Category
High Growth

County Size
Small (10k–20k)

Reference Period
Q2 2024 – Q2 2025

Pender County demonstrated strong economic performance from Q2 2024 to Q2 2025, with employment growth of **7.94%**, wage growth of **7.56%**, and establishment growth of **9.62%**. All three metrics substantially exceed the statewide average.

Key Economic Indicators

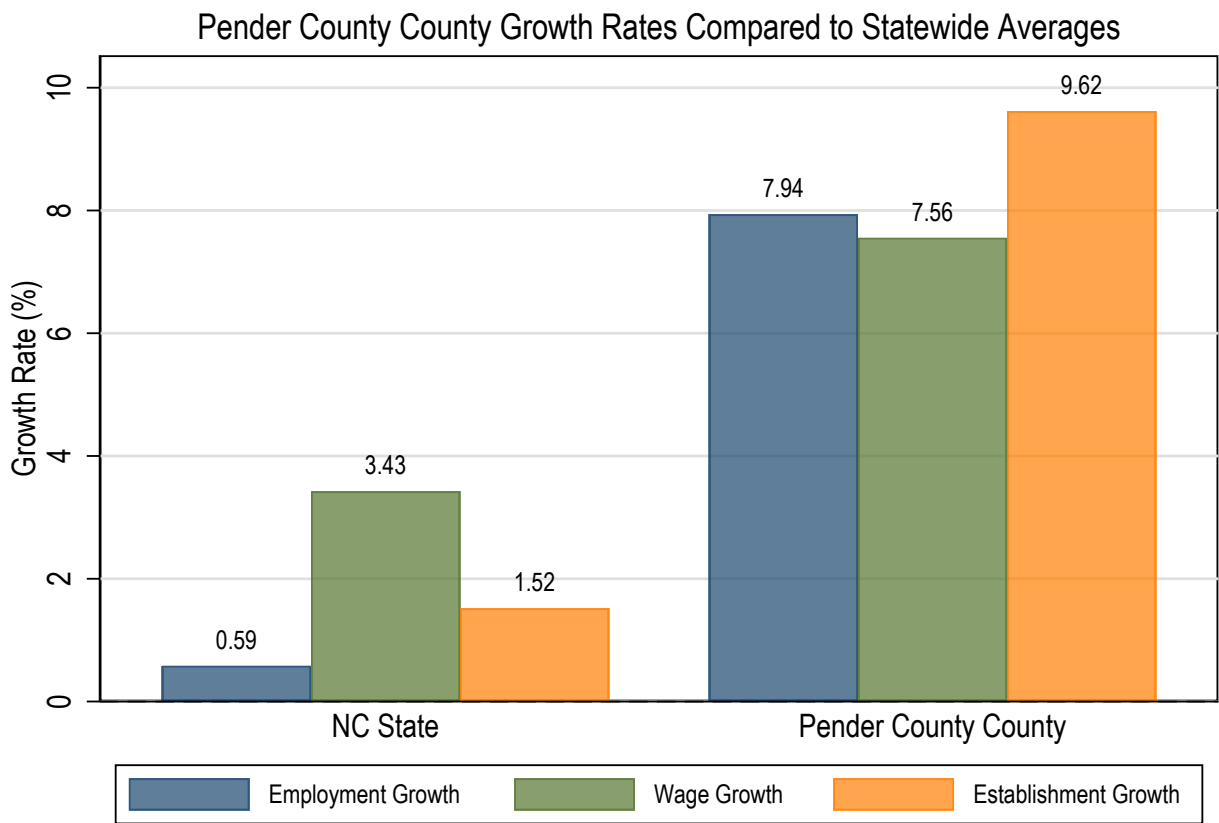
Metric	Q2 2024	Q2 2025	Change	% Change
Employment				
Total Employment <i>vs. NC Average</i>	15,187	16,393	+1,206	+7.94% <i>+7.35 pp</i>
Wages				
Avg. Weekly Wage <i>vs. NC Average</i>	\$860	\$925	+\$65	+7.56% <i>[+4.13 pp]</i>
Avg. Annual Wage	\$44,743	\$48,078	+\$3,335	+7.45%
Business Establishments				
Total Establishments <i>vs. NC Average</i>	1,944	2,131	+187	+9.62% <i>+8.10 pp</i>
Employees per Establishment	7.81	7.69	−0.12	−1.53%
Total Wage Bill				
Total Quarterly Wages	\$169.9M	\$197.0M	+\$27.2M	+15.98%

Table 1: Pender County economic performance metrics, Q2 2024 vs. Q2 2025. “pp” = percentage points relative to NC statewide average. NC employment growth: 0.59%; NC wage growth: 3.43%; NC establishment growth: 1.52%.

What does this tell us?: Pender County is experiencing above-average economic growth across all major indicators, with particularly strong performance in business formation (+8.10 pp above state) and employment growth (+7.35 pp above state).

How Does Pender County Compare?

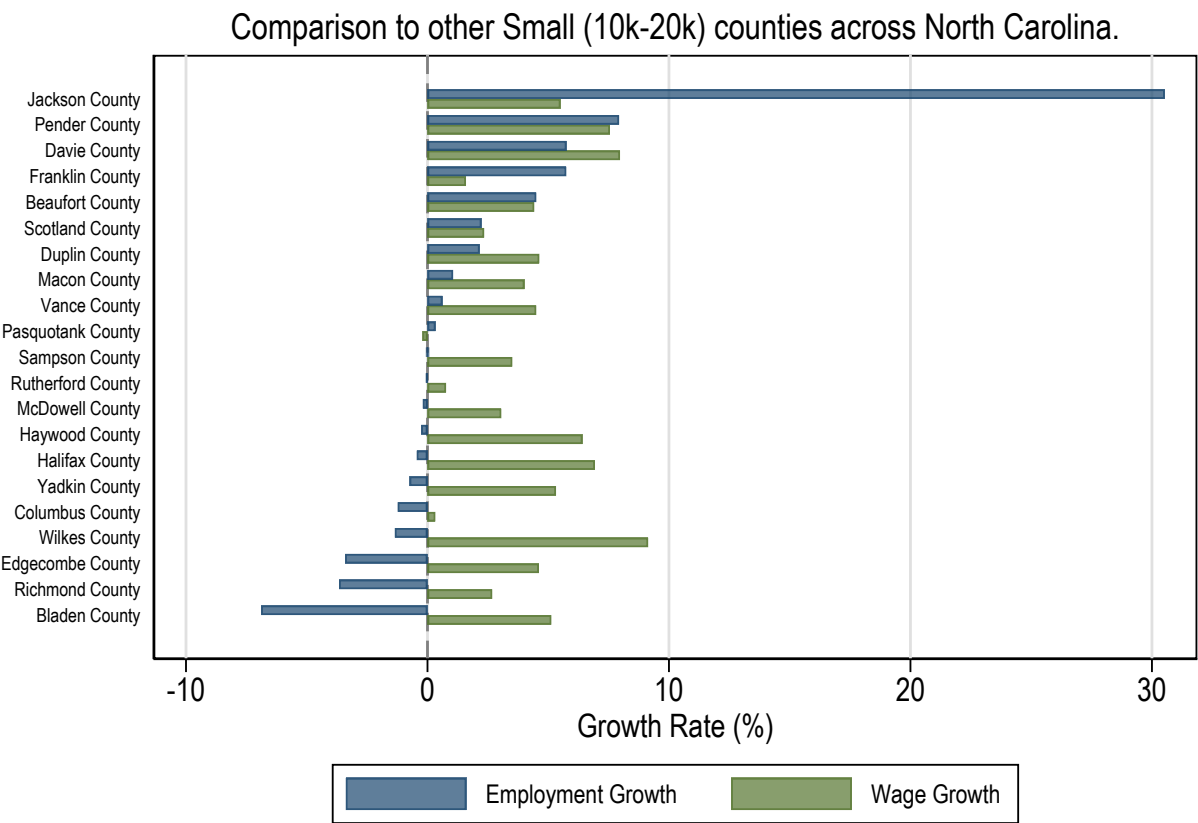
Comparison to North Carolina Statewide Average



Source: BLS QCEW Data, Q2 2024 vs Q2 2025

Figure 1: Pender County growth rates compared to statewide averages. All three key metrics substantially exceed state performance.

Comparison to Similar-Sized Counties



Source: BLS QCEW Data, Q2 2024 vs Q2 2025

Figure 2: Comparison to other small (10k–20k employee) counties across North Carolina.

Position Among All NC Counties

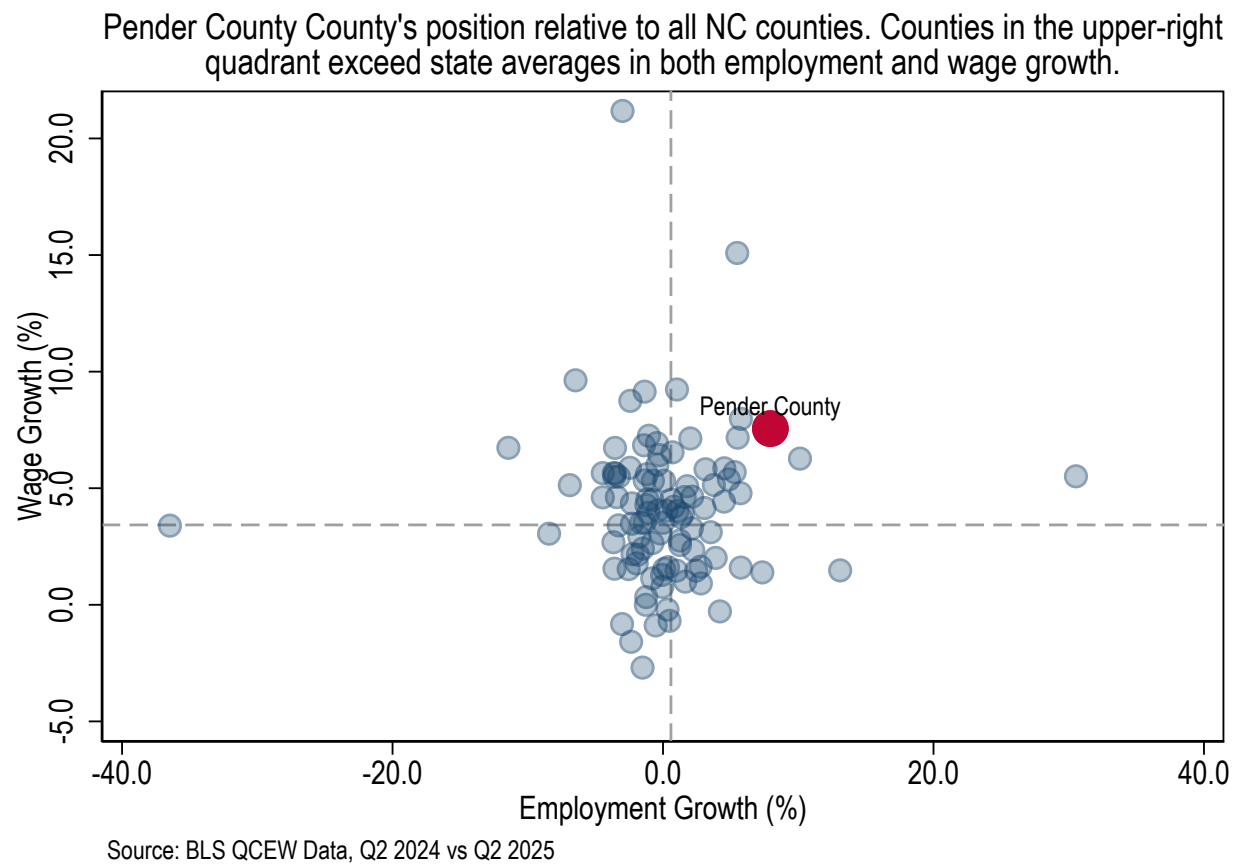


Figure 3: Pender County’s position relative to all NC counties. Counties in the upper-right quadrant exceed state averages in both employment and wage growth.

Findings and Policy Implications

What the Numbers Tell Us

Employment Growth

Pender County's **7.94%** employment growth dramatically outpaced the NC state average of **0.59%**, a difference of **7.35 percentage points**. This places Pender County in the top tier of NC counties by employment growth.

Wage Growth

Average weekly wages increased from \$860 to \$925 (**+7.56%**) versus the state average of **3.43%** (**+4.13 pp**) reaching an annual equivalent of **\$48,078**. This indicates that new jobs being created are not just numerous but also of meaningful quality.

Business Formation

With **9.62%** establishment growth versus the state average of **1.52%** (**+8.10 pp**), Pender County added 187 net new businesses in one year. Stable firm size (7.81 to 7.69 employees per establishment) suggests balanced growth between new formation and existing business expansion.

Tax Base Impact

The total quarterly wage bill grew by **15.98%** (+\$27.2 million), from \$169.9M to \$197.0M. This compounded growth in both employment and wages signals a meaningfully expanding local tax base.

Summary

Pender County's performance positions it favorably among both regional peers and similar-sized counties statewide. The county demonstrates balanced growth across employment, wages, and establishments, indicating a healthy and diversifying economy. The simultaneous expansion of both jobs and wages is particularly noteworthy, as it suggests the county is attracting quality employment rather than simply adding low-wage positions.

Data source: Quarterly Census of Employment and Wages (QCEW), Bureau of Labor Statistics.